FOR KIKI / SAN DIEGO

Coastal Lasagna

A recipe keepsake from Mel



Fresh mozzarella. Four colors of pepper. A generous table, with more for tomorrow.

FEEDS 8–10 PEOPLE

Kiki's ingredients, with a suggested home-chef method. Preparation and timings are proposed and have not been tested for this combination. Corrected October 15, 2026 with Mercedes' notes: cook the noodles first; tomato cans 14.5 oz; Carbone sauce 24 oz jars; feeds 8–10.

THE FULL BATCH

The ingredients



- 32 oz whole milk ricotta
- 32 oz fresh mozzarella (not shredded)
- 1 red, yellow, orange & green pepper, diced*
- 1 sweet Vidalia onion
- 8 cloves of garlic
- 8 oz fresh mushrooms
- 8 sprigs fresh basil, chopped
- 3 sprigs fresh oregano, chopped
- 1 can marzano tomatoes (14.5 oz)
- 2 cans diced fire roasted tomatoes (14.5 oz each)
- 2 jars Carbone spaghetti sauce (24 oz each)
- 1/4 cup tomato paste
- 1 cup ketchup
- 1 package lasagne noodles (cooked first)
- 2 lbs ground beef or Impossible
- Maldon sea salt
- Cracked black pepper
- Lawry's garlic salt

Feeds 8–10 people, with leftovers. Set out two deep 9 × 13-inch pans and a spare small dish.

*One pepper of each color is an interpretation, pending confirmation. Can and jar sizes confirmed by Mercedes: tomato cans 14.5 oz, Carbone sauce 24 oz jars. Seasoning amounts are to taste.

SUGGESTED HOME-CHEF METHOD

The preparation

01 · Prepare the kitchen

Cook the lasagne noodles first, following the package directions until just tender; drain and lay them flat so they do not stick. Drain and blot thinly sliced or torn fresh mozzarella. Drain pooled whey from the ricotta. Set out two deep 9 × 13-inch pans plus a spare small dish.

02 · Build a generous sauce

Brown the ground beef or Impossible in batches to 160°F, then remove. Cook the mushrooms until excess water evaporates. Soften diced onion and peppers, add minced garlic briefly, then cook the tomato paste for 1–2 minutes. Return the protein and vegetables. Add all tomatoes with their juices, both jars of sauce, the ketchup and oregano. Simmer gently for 20–30 minutes, retaining a generous, pourable sauce. Add some basil toward the end. Season cautiously with salt, black pepper and garlic salt.

03 · Layer with care

Mix the ricotta with some chopped basil and black pepper. Spread sauce across the bottom of each pan. Add a single layer of the cooked noodles with minimal overlap. Cover generously with sauce, then add ricotta and mozzarella. Repeat the layers. Leave ½–1 inch of headroom and reserve some mozzarella for the finish. Divide all ingredients between the pans and spare dish as needed.

04 · Bake until tender

Cover tightly with foil and place on rimmed trays. Bake at 350°F for an estimated 60–90 minutes, checking from 60 minutes. The pasta must be tender throughout and the center reach 165°F. Package directions take precedence over this estimated timing.

05 · Finish, rest, share

Uncover, add the reserved mozzarella and bake for an estimated 10–20 minutes until browned. Rest for 20–30 minutes before cutting. Serves 8–10 people, with leftovers.

06 · Keep the leftovers

Refrigerate in shallow portions within 2 hours. Keep refrigerated for 3–4 days and reheat to 165°F.

Mercedes' notes

Cook the noodles first, before layering — that is Mercedes’ way. Tomato cans are 14.5 oz each and the Carbone sauce comes in 24 oz jars; sizes confirmed by Mercedes. The pepper count is interpreted as one of each color, pending confirmation. Seasoning quantities are to taste.

Guidance: USDA food safety · Impossible cooking guidance · BelGioioso fresh mozzarella lasagna. These sources inform the proposed method; they do not test this ingredient combination.

A keepsake for Kiki, prepared for Mel. Food imagery is AI-generated; the recipe method is a suggested adaptation.